

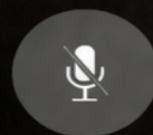
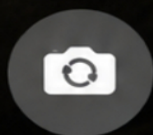
FaceTime

00:13

Girlfriend Gone Astray

I guess that guy wasn't just a friend

—  —
Evan Slate



GIRLFRIEND GONE ASTRAY

I guess that guy wasn't just a friend

Evan Slate

PMI

Copyright © 2026 Evan Slate

All rights reserved

The characters and events portrayed in this book are fictitious. Any similarity to real persons, living or dead, is coincidental and not intended by the author.

No part of this book may be reproduced, or stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise, without express written permission of the publisher.

In retrospect, things didn't add up.

Ashley told me she was going to bed early the night before, blew me a kiss on our call, told me she was overtired, and warned me she was turning her phone off, so not to even try texting or calling.

"Well I hope you get a good long sleep," I said.

"I sure hope so! Nite honey."

But then I accidentally texted her when I meant to text my friend about the game, and the text read as "delivered," which I know is a small thing, but I happen to know it wouldn't do that if a phone is powered down.

I brushed it off. Maybe she forgot to power it down.

I was at work the next day doing a small job estimate in her neighborhood and thought it would be fun to put a flower in a vase on her counter to surprise her when she got home later. We had only recently exchanged keys. I felt like it was a very strong sign.

She normally kept her place pretty neat and tidy. In fact she often liked tidying up and cleaning my place, she so loved order and neatness so much.

But her place this day as anything but. It made me wonder if she really was feeling off. There were dishes on the counter, clothes on the floor, even a wine glass... and a beer can.

I came over later. The vase with the flower was moved from the kitchen counter to the bathroom oddly.

I came out and chuckled. "It's like you were trying to hide my present!" I said, carrying the vase out of the bathroom.

She was already dressed in her customary drawstring shorts and t-shirt and slumped deep on the couch.

"Your present?" she said with her eyes narrowed. "Oh yeah, well, I wanted to look at it when I came out of the shower!"

I laughed some more and put it on the counter again and went to plop down beside her. "More like in the shower," I said. I'd found it on the floor

of the bathtub with the curtains closed. Which by itself is not surprising, she kept them closed to dry after a shower.

“Thank you so much for it!” she said. “I forgot to thank you when I came home.”

“Just a little thing,” I said, and I shrugged modestly. “You sleep good night last?”

“Yeah, sure,” she said with disinterest, now scanning through shows for us to watch. “You?”

“Well, just that you said you were going to bed early, before you came down with something.”

“Mmm?” she said, dropping the remote and snaking her hands around my arm to pull me down with her deeper into the couch we were nearly laying in now, our legs out across the coffee table. Her place, by the time I came back around 7 was back to its typical ship-shape form.

We kissed, her face turning up, her eyes fluttering closed. “You turned your phone off to make sure nothing woke you up,” I said.

But she pushed her fingers through the hair on the back of my head, pulled my head down over hers, and invaded my mouth with her tongue.

“Have I ever told you how good I feel with you?” she said when we came apart. “You’re like a rock for me, truly you are.”

I felt it again, that swelling price, that beat of anticipation. First the keys, now lots of talk from her like this. It really felt like maybe we really were just perfect for each other.

Neither of us were the going out clubbing types, or the big parties or the drinking games kind of thing. We liked shows, we liked long drives, we liked staying at home.

“I could tell you weren’t feeling great when I snuck in at lunch time to drop the flower off for you,” I said.

“That was you,” she said absently.

“Of course it was me, who would it be?” I said, laughing.

She laughed too, and pulled me down for another even longer kiss.

Ashley worked as an assistant special event coordinator at this huge hotel downtown. Usually she had regular shifts at work, but if something big was on, it was all hands on deck. So sometimes she had unexpected later times at work, other times, she had afternoons or whole days off to make up the time.

She couldn't get out of it if they needed her, no matter what plans her and I had. "So, so sorry, babe!" she said, calling me at around 5, her usual off work time.

I had a proper date planned, dinner, movie out, and then who knows what later back at her place...

"I'm used to it," I said with exaggerated disappointment.

"Aw, sweetie, you know I'll make it up to you."

"You better!" I said, with more mock sternness.

"Oh..." she cooed. "Look who's taking control now!"

"You just wait," I joked.

"So I don't know how late this dumb thing is going to go, so I'll just say goodnight to you now, okay?"

"Yeah," I said. "I might hit the hay early anyway. Save up my strength for later..."

She laughed and told me goodnight and blew me a kiss. She warned me she was going to be very busy, so not to even try to call.

But as soon as we ended our call, I thought of leaving food in her fridge for her if she came home hungry. I tried calling her right back, but her phone went to messages. She was somehow already on another call.

I went out to pick up some dinner for myself and drove back to her place before I slapped myself on the forehead having forgot to order anything for her. Oh well, I thought, I wasn't sure if she wanted anything anyway, and I carried on home.

But in passing by her building, I noticed dim lights on up in her place. She didn't seem all that enamored to learn before that I was in her place without her for the flower, so I thought better of dashing up to turn out the lights she forgot. It was no biggy, it was more just the kind of thing that bugged me.

True to her word, when I called her later, having forgot what she told me about probably not being able to take calls, she never answered. It was about 10, so that wasn't too out of the ordinary for a big event night.

But by 12, I'd called her about 4 times and still got no answer. Now worried, I got out of bed, got dressed, and drove back around to her place. It wasn't that far. Driving by, I saw the earlier light now off. Okay, I thought, she got home, was totally wiped, and just crashed out instantly to sleep. It wouldn't be the first time. I went back home and back to bed relieved she was safe and sound.

I few days later, I face-timed her and laughed about how I worried about her so much I drove by after midnight. I made a mistake and told her it was then that I saw her lights on.

“Oh yeah,” she said. Mason came over, we were just hanging out getting a drink.”

“Mason?”

“Oh yeah, he was part of the crew again for that special event thing that night. Crazy right?”

Mason was one of her best friend’s older brother. He was some audio technician for live events and small concerts type of thing.

This guy was the classic no schedule, no ties, no commitments type of modern wild man. I truth I envied him. I tried to imagine at time what it would be like to live so free of any social obligations. In the end I never saw the appeal long term. But Ashley seemed to tolerate him. She explained it as her outreach, and laughed. “I’ve always taken in stray cats and give them pats and water and kibbles,” she laughed.

“Mason was over that night?”

“We had to unwind, the whole thing was a shit-show, we had to debrief.”

“So he came over for a bit,” I said.

“You can really only come down from something like that with someone who was in the trenches with you, you know?” she said.

She was in a towel. “You caught me on the way to the shower,” she explained. But I could see behind her, her room was in a mess again.

“No, yeah, I totally get it,” I said. It wasn’t the first time Mason was over at her place. They were in similar work, after all, he doing set ups for shows, and her hotel putting on a lot of those type of shows, and she’d be right in the thick of it as one of the organizers.

“Oh I forgot,” I said. “It was when I was out to get food, I saw your lights on. When I was out checking on your after midnight, they were all off, so yeah.”

“Mason stayed over,” she offered.

I was startled by the information, not sure how it related to my mix-up with the lights.

“He stayed over?”

“It’s nothing, it’s just Mason, are you kidding?” she laughed.

“No I’m just surprised.”

“It was so late by the time we sort of got through it all, you know? Why drive home?”

“Why, yeah, I get that. Like maybe on the couch, sort of thing.”

She laughed and shook her head at me on the screen. “Well what do you think?”

I thought I saw a shadow flash across the back of the wall. She was FaceTiming me in her bedroom. I decided it must have been her cat.

“Listen, I got to go, I need to shower and stuff, I really need to get to bed early tonight.”

“Okay,” I said. “Good to see you even if it’s just like this,” I laughed.

“It’s going to have to be all you get, sweetness,” she said, and she laughed too.

We said goodnight and blew kisses. However, just as I was ending the call, it appeared as though a hand wrapped around her forearm. Her eyes darted down, but the screen went blank. It’s the kind of thing that, at 1 millisecond, your mind quickly convinces itself you were seeing something, you were imagining it.

And I knew I was a likely candidate for little hallucinations. There were several small signals lately that were beginning to add up to something in the back of my mind that I was careful to stuff back inside a box I had no interest in opening.

A couple weeks later Ashley invited me to this little get together at her friend Nicole’s place. She tried to talk me out of it at first.

“You’ll totally hate it,” she laughed over the phone. “It’s all event people and music people and loud drunk idiots.”

“Wow,” I said. “Sounds truly amazing.”

“I’m serious,” she said. “You’ll be bored to death.”

But I pushed. I had a vague feeling lately of always hearing about things after the fact. It was a side of Ashley I hardly ever got to witness.

“Maybe I want to see inside your world a little,” I laughed.

“Aww,” she said softly. “Okay, sweetness. But when you’re miserable later I reserve the right to say I told you so.”

The moment we walked in I realized I’d misunderstood what kind of “little” thing this was. I’d pictured maybe ten people sitting around with drinks talking. Instead the place was packed shoulder to shoulder. Music

was pounding through the condo. People spilled into the kitchen, onto the balcony, down the hall.

Ashley instantly came alive beside me.

“Oh my God, there you are!” some girl screamed from across the room, and Ashley broke away from me laughing and vanished into the crowd before turning and grabbing my wrist again to drag me after her.

“This is exactly what I meant,” she laughed. “Too many people, right?” She said back over her shoulder to me, quoting a line I used so much it became our inside joke.

But she looked happy and so I was too.

I got a beer and sort of settled around the edges of things while Ashley floated directly through them naturally, moving from group to group. She kept coming back to me every once in a while, kissing my cheek, rubbing my shoulder, introducing me to somebody else whose name I forgot instantly.

Then Mason arrived.

You always knew when Mason entered a room because all attention went to him. He came through the front door already laughing about something, two people behind him carrying bottles. Ashley’s whole face changed when she spotted him, at once both disdainful and excited.

“So the caveman arriveth,” she murmured to me staring across the room at him.

Mason spotted her at the same time and pointed dramatically. “Ashes to ashes!” he shouted across the room.

Ashley burst out laughing before he’d even reached us. He came straight over and wrapped both arms around her waist from behind hard enough that she stumbled backward into him with a yelp.

“Jesus Christ,” she laughed. “You a fucking brute!”

“Miss me?” he grinned, pushing his face into her hair and neck. He lifted her clear off the floor.

“No!” she said instantly, although she was still laughing.

He barely acknowledged me at first beyond a quick “Hey man,” before his attention swung right back to Ashley. It wasn’t rude exactly, just automatic between them, like their conversation had already been going on before he even entered the room.

He took her with him almost like he was carrying her on his hip. I saw her in the kitchen playfully feeding him some snack to his mouth, Mason

making a joke of biting her finger before sucking on it.

“Get your own!” she laughed.

“But you the good stuff!” he shouted, and everyone in the kitchen laughed.

“You’re going to so get it,” she said more privately to him with narrow eyes and a tight grin.

She twisted around with an exaggerated annoyed expression and shoved a piece of food toward his mouth to shut him up. Everybody around them laughed more. Mason caught her wrist before she could pull away and grinned around the bite.

Later, me mostly hanging by myself at the end of the couch, I saw Ashley bent forward laughing at something somebody said while Mason stood behind her with his arm looped low around her waist. He pulled her backward against him, absentmindedly while still talking to somebody else.

Her ass pressed directly into his groin as her body hung over his arm like a rug on a line, she was laughing so hard. I stared at this because it felt so openly physical for somebody who supposedly irritated her so much.

Ashley looked over and saw me watching. She rolled her eyes and mouthed “See?” and she shook her head with exasperation.

Later she escaped back over beside me and collapsed dramatically against my shoulder.

“I swear to God,” she said. “He’s like a dog that never learned manners.”

“You seem pretty popular tonight,” I said lightly.

She narrowed her eyes at me immediately. “I told you you wouldn’t enjoy it.”

“I’m not saying anything,” I said and I laughed.

“Good,” she said. Then she kissed me quickly. “Because you’re my all time favorite person here.”

Toward the end of the night Mason dropped heavily into an armchair near the balcony and caught Ashley by the wrist as she walked past.

“Sit,” he said.

“I’m not your dog.”

“Sit!”

“I’m not sitting on you, you idiot.”

But he tugged harder and she fell backward sideways across his lap laughing while people around them whooped and shouted.

Ashley looked over at me from across the room with this helpless little shrug on her face as if to say, “what can I do?”

Mason wrapped one arm around her stomach and held her tight while he kept talking to everybody else like there was nothing unusual about it.

I stood there with my beer half lifted and waited for the moment Ashley would get off him. At first Ashley sat stiffly sideways across Mason’s lap like somebody only there temporarily while people laughed and talked around them.

“Oh my God,” she groaned. “You are such a disaster.”

“Yet here you are,” Mason said.

“I am literally kidnapped.”

People near them laughed. If I’d walked into a party and saw another guy’s girlfriend sitting in somebody’s lap like that, I would have thought it was a huge deal. But nobody reacted like there was anything strange about it.

Ashley looked over at me again and rolled her eyes with a helpless grin, like we were both enduring Mason together.

But slowly, over the next little while, her body changed. The stiffness left her. Her shoulders fell. She stopped holding herself upright. Mason’s arm remained spread low across her stomach and after awhile I noticed Ashley absently wrapping her fingers around his thumb where his hand rested against her down low. She sank down and into him no longer glancing up at me. She seemed lost in her own thoughts, or just listening to people.

It looked too natural. too comfortable.

At one point Mason said something into the side of her head that I couldn’t hear over the music and Ashley threw her head back laughing so hard against his shoulder that her hair brushed across his face.

Ashley caught me watching that. She mouthed something like “help me!” before laughing again and leaning more heavily back against him.

I actually smiled back at her. I thought she was managing him, that she was humoring him because that was just who Mason was, loud, physical, overfamiliar, and impossible.

But his fingers slowly flexed against her stomach now beneath her shirt. Ashley reaching blindly behind herself for his drink and took a sip from it without asking, tipped it at his mouth too.

Her legs stretched comfortably across the empty couch beside them now like she had fully settled into him. Mason barely even looked down at her anymore, I guess because having her in his lap already seemed ordinary to him.

Nicole wandered over beside me carrying drinks.

“You surviving your first?” she said, laughing with her head back.

“Barely.”

“I told Ashley this crowd might be a lot for you.”

“Yeah well,” I laughed. “She did warn me.”

Nicole glanced across the room toward Ashley and Mason and smirked. “Those two are always ridiculous at these industry parties. I don’t think you have to worry, though,” she said, but she also flared her eyes at me before she moved on.

Something about her wording lodged itself with me, Those two, and Always.

I looked back over at them. Mason was talking to somebody across the room while Ashley sat curled even more comfortably against him listening, rubbing his thumb loosely against her stomach like she’d forgotten she was doing it at all.

She came to find me about an hour later. “We can go if you want,” she said. She had clearly been drinking, not wildly, but enough that she leaned heavily into me in the elevator on the way down laughing at absolutely nothing.

“Oh my God,” she groaned. “I am totally exhausted.”

“You seemed pretty energized upstairs.”

She burst out laughing again. “Because Mason is literally a human drug!”

I laughed too despite myself.

Outside, the cold air hit both of us. Ashley instantly tucked herself into my side while we walked toward my car.

“You had fun though?” she asked, peering up at me carefully.

“Yeah,” I said. “I guess so.”

“You guess so?”

“It was just louder and crazier than I expected.”

“I did warn you,” she laughed. “That crowd is insane.”

When we got to the car she kicked off her shoes immediately and folded one leg beneath herself in the seat facing me while I drove. She looked soft

and happy and affectionate in that slightly drunk way people sometimes do after a long night.

“I think I liked having you there,” she said quietly after awhile.

“Yeah?”

“Mm-hm.” She reached over and played with my fingers resting on the console between us. “I know that whole world is not your thing.”

“It is your thing, that’s for sure.”

She made a face immediately. “Only in small doses. People like Mason are built for it. I’m not. I just make my appearances. I couldn’t go on like that.”

I glanced over at her. “You two seem pretty comfortable.”

Ashley groaned loudly and dropped her forehead against the cold window dramatically. “Oh my God, can you believe Mason? That man cannot take no! Did you not see how he had his hands all over me the whole night?”

“No,” I laughed. “I didn’t see that.”

“He’s an animal!” she said. “You saw him. He manhandles everybody.”

I laughed again and shook my head.

“I swear to God,” she continued. “Half the time when I’m with him I feel like I’m supervising a drunk golden retriever.”

“And sitting in his lap?” I asked also in a light tone.

Ashley turned back toward me instantly with a huge smile. “What was I supposed to do? Create a scene in front of everybody? He likes it,” she shrugged. “We’re just really old friends.”

“You looked pretty comfortable over there.”

She narrowed her eyes suspiciously at me, although she was still smiling. “You are jealous!”

“I’m not jealous.”

“You’re a little jealous,” she sang softly with a wide grin.

Then she leaned across the console and kissed me slowly while I sat stopped at a red light.

“You’re cute when you get possessive,” she murmured against my mouth. “I like it, you know.”

The light turned green and behind us and somebody honked immediately. Ashley burst out laughing and dropped back into her seat while I shook my head smiling despite myself.

“There,” she said smugly. “Now stop worrying about that brute caveman.”

A couple of weeks later Ashley told me she was going to some live music thing downtown to meet a few people from her work.

“Do not make fun of me,” she warned over the phone. “But apparently this band is extremely important to people who wear combat boots indoors.”

I laughed. “I would never make fun of you.”

“You absolutely would.”

I surprised her by coming over straight from work with a plan to drive her downtown myself. We hadn’t made concrete plans for that Friday night anyway, and I thought maybe afterward we could grab food or she could come back to my place.

But when Ashley opened the door quickly with a big smile, she blinked in surprise.

“Oh!” she said. “Hi!”

Then she brought the smile quickly back and kissed me. “What are you doing here?” she said as she turned to return to the bathroom.

“Thought I’d chauffeur you around the glamorous downtown music scene.”

Ashley laughed, but there was this tiny hesitation before she answered. “Oh, baby, but Mason’s already picking me up. I’m sorry. It’s his thing, I don’t even know...”

I stopped almost immediately inside because she looked completely different.

Ashley usually dressed pretty simply when we were going out, a little makeup, jeans, sweaters, sneakers. She was naturally pretty enough that she never needed much else and I told her that.

But tonight she was in a dark fitted dress with blue suede peep toe heels on. Her makeup was heavier than I had ever really seen on her before, grey eye shadow, dark liner around her eyes, lip gloss flashing with the apartment lights every time she moved her mouth.

Her hair was done too, blown out full and thick around her shoulders in loose waves like she was going out clubbing.

“You look...” I started.

Ashley grinned immediately. “Too much?”

“No,” I said honestly. “You look amazing.”

She instantly blushed at that and turned back toward the mirror hanging near her kitchen. “Nicole said everybody gets totally dressed up at this place.” She pulled a strand of hair down the side of her face.

“What place is it anyway?”

“Just some live music bar downtown?”

“A bar?” I said before I could stop myself.

Ashley looked over immediately. “What?”

“Nothing, I just thought concert meant like actual concert.”

“It is an actual concert,” she laughed. “Just at one of those places.”

I watched her apply another careful layer of gloss in the mirror.

“So who all is going again?”

Ashley hesitated.

“I think everybody bailed actually,” she said.

“Everybody?”

“Well, not me and Mason, so I don’t know, just him and me now I guess.” She laughed.

“Just you two?”

“Yeah, but it wasn’t planned that way” she said quickly. “Everybody is such a flake.”

“Well I could come then,” I offered casually.

Ashley laughed immediately and all too quickly.

“Colin,” she said. “You would hate this with every fiber of your being.”

“I might survive.”

“No, you would not,” she said, still smiling while slipping on one of her high heels. “Trust me. Sweaty people screaming lyrics over terrible beer while Mason yells in your ear about sound systems for four hours is not your thing.”

I laughed a little too, but weakly.

“Besides,” she said, tilting her head at me, her expression going soft and sympathetic. “You’re my safe room, you’re my steady rock, my anchor. I don’t want you falling prey to the seductions of the boozing and drugging night life!” she said and she kissed my nose.

“But what about you?”

She came away from me and checked herself in the mirror again. “Babe, I have to do this, without building connections in the industry, I’ll never get out of the rat hole I’m stuck in downtown at that big dumb boomer hotel.”

“Well maybe I’ll just stay here then,” I said. “Wait up for you after your big punk rock adventure so you can tell me all about it.”

Ashley opened her mouth. “Yeah! Of course, you can just...” Then she stopped. “Actually,” she started to say slowly, “Maybe not tonight.”

“Why?”

She kept adjusting the strap on her dress without looking up. “I just mean... I know you don’t totally trust Mason.”

“I never said I don’t trust him!” I said.

“But you know what I mean.”

“No, I don’t, actually.”

She sighed softly, rolled her eyes to the side, and finally looked at me. “He might stay over here again after.”

I just stared at her.

“It’s not a thing,” she said quickly. “It’s just, he lives too far away and he’s already driving me downtown and back, I mean it’s the least I can do, it’s just a favor.”

I looked around and noticed the bottle of wine on the counter, and two glasses.

Ashley followed my eyes and laughed immediately. “Oh my God,” she said. “Would you relax? The wine is from when I was getting ready.”

“I didn’t say anything.”

“You’re thinking things very loudly though.” She patted my stomach and shook her head.

Her buzzer sounded from downstairs.

Ashley looked toward it and her entire expression brightened before she looked back at me again trying now to suppress it.

“That’ll be the caveman calling,” she said lightly and she laughed abruptly at her joke.

“I’ll lock up for you, just go,” I said.

“You are Saint Colin,” she said and she kissed me quickly before heading downstairs. I saw her check herself in the mirror beside the door before she pushed her hair back with both hands, leaned closer toward her reflection, and touched one fingertip lightly against the gloss on her lower lip.

“Do you know you are completely ridiculous?” I laughed.

“What?” she said in mock defensiveness, and she smiled too.

“You look like you’re heading to the Grammys.”

“Oh shut up,” she said, grabbing her purse. “I never get to go out anymore.”

“You look like you’re going on a hot date,” I said.

She came up to me and draped her arms around my neck. “It’s just with Mason, you know Mason,” she said softly.

I was drawn to her, came to her and closed my eyes, yearned to kiss her. But she pulled back. “You’re going to smear my perfect lips.”

“Before Mason sees them.”

“Before Mason sees them,” she nearly whispered with her forehead rocking against my forehead. I was nearly overcome with the scent of her perfume. “Don’t be jealous?” she murmured.

I slipped my hands around her waist. “But he’s always around you, grabbing you, touching you,” I murmured back.

“I know,” she whispered and she juttred her hips subtly, pressed herself to my hips.

“He was pulling you into his lap.”

She didn’t form words to reply this time, only took a short, sharp inhaled gasp. Her body pressed against me harder, and she rotated her hips now.

“He was playing in your hair in front of me, baby,” I said.

“He was,” she groaned, and this time she sank her mouth over mine, pushed her tongue between my teeth.

“He was holding you around your waist.”

She only moaned in a high pitch, pushing me back against the fridge.

“What happened when he slept over?” I said.

“Baby,” she exhaled with a sharp breath. She was breathing hard now. “Just don’t, okay?” she managed to squeeze out in a shaking whisper.

The buzzer sounded again, longer this time, impatient.

Ashley rolled her eyes. “See? I told you he’s an absolute animal.” She pulled away from me, went to the mirror, reapplied her gloss. “I have to go, he’s going to freak out if we’re not at a good table.”

I followed her down. Mason’s truck sat double parked outside her building with music thumping softly through the open windows. Mason himself leaned across the passenger seat to shove the door open for Ashley the moment we stepped outside.

“There she is!” he called out.

Ashley laughed and shook her head before looking back toward me.
“I’ll text you later, okay? I’ll really try.”

“Have fun.”

Mason pointed toward me from across the cab. “Don’t worry, bud, I’ll bring her home in one piece, more or less.” He laughed out loud.

“I’d appreciate that,” I said and I laughed and waved.

Ashley climbed up into his truck, smoothing her short tight dress beneath herself while Mason watched her with an openly amused grin on his face. Then she looked back out at me through the open window and blew me a kiss before they pulled away into traffic. I saw her body jerk sideways as though he pulled her hard toward him.

Around ten Ashley sent me a picture from the bar. The place looked packed wall to wall with people beneath red lights and neon beer signs. Mason’s face was partly visible beside hers in the frame, smiling toward the camera while Ashley laughed with her head tipped sideways and back against his shoulder.

“You could be here right now, lol,” the message said.

I laughed despite myself and texted back: “You both look very sophisticated...”

A minute later: “dumb Mason just spilled beer on somebody!”

It felt normal again somehow, just Ashley out with those loud chaotic people while I sat at home watching playoff highlights and eating takeout.

But after that her texts slowed down.

At around eleven thirty I sent one:

“How’s the terrible music?”

But nothing came back.

At midnight I tried video calling her just to joke around, intending to make some comment about rescuing her from the caveman. The call connected for less than one second before cutting out instantly.

Then a text arrived almost immediately: “Too loud lol”

“You heading home soon?”

Around one fifteen another message finally came. “back at my place. exhausted!!!”

I replied right away: “Did Mason just drop you off?”

But there was nothing back from her. I waited awhile longer before sending to her again, “Night sweetness”

The message showed delivered immediately but no reply came after that.

The next morning Ashley called me around ten. Her voice sounded rough and low like she had been yelling over loud music all night.

“Good morning, you,” she mumbled.

“You sound destroyed.”

“I honestly might be dead.”

I laughed. “Worth it?”

“Oh my God no. That band was horrible.”

I could hear movement in the background, cabinets opening and closing, dishes clinking softly together.

“Your at home?” I asked.

“Mm-hm.”

“Alone?”

There was the tiniest pause.

“Not quite” she said. Then in a smaller voice, she said, “He stayed over obviously. He was not capable of driving anywhere after.”

“Right.”

Later I came by with coffee and breakfast sandwiches because Ashley did say she was too hungover to function. She opened the door wearing a large men’s t-shirt I didn’t recognize and tiny sleep shorts with her hair piled messily on top of her head. She smiled sleepily the moment she saw me and wrapped both arms around my waist.

“You are my hero,” she groaned into my chest and she took my hand and lad me into the kitchen.

We passed the bedroom and I peered in. Her bed was a total disaster.

“Rough night,” she said with a shrug. Then she kissed me slowly and draped her arms over my shoulders.

“Can I make you deal?” she said in a low and quiet voice.

I held her around her waist and we slowly rocked together. That’s when I heard the shower, I noticed it when the water went off.

“Why don’t you leave both coffees and sandwiches here for now, go back out and get another one for yourself, and I promise,” she said, sinking her tongue deep in my mouth and kissing me with sloppy passion. “You’ll have me all to yourself.”

I turned when I heard the bathroom door open and saw Mason step out fresh from the shower naked with a towel around his shoulders and rubbing

it in his hair. He didn't even look up the hallway, didn't know I was there.

"Ashes, get back in here, round two," he called, and I heard him laugh.

"Sh-sh," Ashley said to me and she took my face in her hands and steered my gaze back to her. She kissed me again and laughed. "He's joking, you know he that man," she said. "But just give me like 15 minutes, okay?"

I stared at her.

She shrugged. "Or maybe like 30?" she said in a tinier voice.

I left, of course. I went back to the cafe where I got her, and I guess Mason, coffees and sandwiches, and took a table outside and stared long and hard across the road and the park over there and the city teeming in the distance.

At exactly 30 minutes, I didn't go back. I FaceTimed her.

It took several rings, and when it was answered, the view was flying around like nobody had a handle on the phone. I heard muffled laughter before things settled on Ashley close up.

She was holding a towel closed over herself and presumably holding the phone with her other hand.

"Babe," she said to the screen as though catching her breath.

"Are you alone?" I said.

"More or less."

"What does that mean?"

"I don't know where he is," she said, her eyes shooting to the side then back to me.

"I need to know, Ash."

"What?"

"What's going on?"

"What do you mean?"

"Ash, he was naked in your bedroom."

"He was going to my bedroom, he wasn't already in there."

"He just showered and was walking around naked like it was nothing."

"I think I had his t-shirt on," she said as though that explained it.

"Are you sleeping with him?"

She inhaled sharply. "That's unfair, Colin!"

"But what do you think it looks like?" I nearly shouted back before I noticed I was outside with people passing by, and I lowered my voice.

"What does it look like?"

She jutted her jaw crookedly and let her eyes wonder up into the corner of her room before she came back to the screen. "Mason has always been there for me, Colin. And you know, he hasn't had the easiest time of it either."

"Meaning?"

"He was raised in a pretty violent household, you don't know anything about it. He never tells anyone about it, he doesn't use excuses, but I know all of it."

"So how does that..."

"Just listen, okay? Can you at least listen?"

"I'm listening..."

She took a while to gather her thoughts. "We've always supported each other and sometimes it feels like it's all we have, just each other. It's this industry, you have to know that."

"He's just a good old friend."

"Just a good old friend! Yes!"

"Who walks around your place naked?"

She snorted and looked away. "It's like a sports team, it's like being on the road, it's like the locker room, you're always naked with your teammates, aren't they?"

"Not men and women together. Alone."

"We help each other out, I let him crash at my place so he doesn't have to drive all the way home, he lets me crash at his place too sometimes, it's all even Steven," she said.

"Quid pro quo," I said.

"Exactly, quid pro quo."

"I don't know, Ashley."

"Colin, you know I lean on you, I depend on you, you're the one I look up to, you're the one I need."

"So how is Mason to you?"

She laughed and rolled her eyes. "He. Is. Just. A. Friend!" she said in spaced out speech.

"I don't know if I can take this, though."

"I know how you're feeling. Look, maybe you just need to get to know him better, would you like that? Like get to know him away from all those crazy people, maybe just you, me, and him, have him over, you can cook one of your great meals. Maybe if you saw how he really is with me, he's

tender, he's sweet when people aren't around, maybe you can... accept him better."

"Are you swearing to me there's nothing going on?"

"Babe, I told you, I depend on you for so much!"

I thought about it long and hard. Her eyes on the screen kept tugging sideways and down. I saw her shake her head subtly. "Is someone there with you now? Is he there with you now?"

"Babe, you have to meet him better, you have to get to know him."

"What, like have him over for dinner?"

"You love to cook, this gives you a chance to show off. He eats at every restaurant in the state, you can really impress him!"

"Like maybe a prawn carbonara, say?"

"There you go, yes! I bet he loves that!"

"Or a bouillabaisse," I said.

"The world is your oyster!" she said and she laughed.

She stumbled forward. "I really should get going."

"You got something?"

"Just got to..." she tried again before she squealed and fell a bit. "Gonna go now, Col, think about it!" she cried out quickly. And then she squealed and fell into the phone laughing, and I saw a male hand pulling on her wrist, pulling her into the chair she was kneeling on.

I gripped my phone so tight just as the call ended that I took a screenshot by accident. It's a photo I've looked at sideways, upside down, from arms length and zoomed in.

Had Mason been holding the camera the whole time? I've put the photo on the cover of this story so you can see for yourself what I was looking at.

But I had a dinner to prepare...

I was at Ashley's apartment all afternoon gathering things and prepping. She came into the kitchen in her towel fresh from the shower, thumbing her phone. "Mason wants to know what to bring."

"In terms of wine?"

She blew a raspberry. "Wine? Mason? You really do not know this man at all, do you."

"So what then?"

"I'll tell him," she murmured as she wrote with her thumbs, "to bring you the best brew pub beer he can think of."

"Fair enough," I said.

“I’m so glad you’re doing this,” she said, and she lifted herself on her toes to slide her hand around my neck and kiss my cheek. “It’s important to me.”

“Hey,” I said, cutting things on the board. “When we were on FaceTime the other day, you were alone, right?”

She tickled me under my chin and turned to go back to the bathroom to get ready. “No babe, was with an entire hockey team the whole night, didn’t you hear me screaming?”

Ashley wanted to get the door and darted past me when Mason arrived. “Are you ready?” she said over her shoulder at me as though I was the one in front of the mirror in the bathroom for two hours.

She was dressed in a tight red sparkling clubbing dress, something new, and had gone all out on her eye shadow and liner and lips and hair. “You don’t mind these absolutely ridiculous shoes, do you?” she said as she picked her foot up behind herself to get them on. These were totally impractical too-high peep toe platform pumps. “Mason is an idiot for them.”

“You mean he likes them?”

“Like them? The man salivates at the sight of them,” she laughed, and she flung open the door and presented herself.

Mason ducked down, slid his hand around the back of her waist, pulled her forward and into him, and if not for his hand holding the 12-pack of local beer, he’d have had both hands around her body. I kept hearing Ashley’s reassurances, “He’s just like that, he’s physical with everybody.”

Only they also kissed, and it wasn’t a short peck either, but a full and long and involved necking.

I cleared my throat in the kitchen down the hallway from them standing there at the stove in my apron.

Mason lifted his face from Ashley’s and they lingered with their eyes longer before he pushed his hand in her hair, tugged it hard enough to jerk her head back, and slid his hand over her ass as she turned to face me.

She slapped his ass as he came up the hallway. “Oh buddy, I can smell something good from all the way out in the hallway.”

“Just a little something,” I said and I shrugged. He came right into the kitchen, grabbed the wooden spoon out of my hand, dipped it into the carbonate sauce, and tipped the spoon at his lips.

I looked directly at Ashley with eyes aflame. One does not do that; at the very least one might allow the cook to do that for you.

She wrapped her arm through my arm. "He's a different man from you," she said sprightly and she chuckled with her shoulders pushed up.

"Mmm! Fuck me!" Mason cried out. He put his face down over the bowl. "I am going to love eating the fuck out of you!" and he came up and laughed looking at me like that was funny too.

He turned to Ashley, pushed his hand in her hair again, rougher this time so that her face tilted back and her grin turned into a grimace. "So hot," he growled. And then, even while her arm was snaked around my arm, he leaned into her and kissed her deeply all over again.

She patted his stomach and pulled away. "Why don't we control ourselves while we have company," she said in a pert voice. "Colin's been getting this big meal ready all day, haven't you Colin."

I pushed my tongue around the front of my teeth and stared into the pot I was reducing. "It's fine," I said.

Ashley had warned me all afternoon that Mason is going to be Mason, which meant he was going to touch her, push her, make jokes. She didn't say kiss her deeply and make out with her. But I promised to give the man a chance.

As it turned out, I could easily see why people gravitated to him. He was charming, he loved his sound work, and he had hilariously funny stories to tell. By the end of our meal around our little kitchen nook table, I forgot that he bugged me so much. He had me laughing, he had me listening completely to his serious stories, and he even had me talking about my work in estimation like it was important and interesting work.

"Yeah I guess it is," I said. "Like you said, without estimation, who would know what anything should be?"

"Right?" he said, nodding at me, raising his eyebrows, refilling my beer glass. I almost didn't notice at all that his hand was up and down Ashley's back, that she had folded her leg under her in her chair and leaned closer to him, or that her hand was on his thigh under the table where she would squeeze or tap him about another story she wanted him to tell me.

He went to use her bathroom and she came to me where I was loading the dishwasher and ran her hand up and down my back. "Not so bad, right?"

"Okay you were right, he's pretty interesting."

“He’s more than interesting, he’s captivating!”

“I wouldn’t go that far,” I said and I chuckled.

“We should watch a show,” she said. “We have his beer.”

“I guess,” I said.

“Well you don’t want to go home, do you? I mean if you need to...”

“No, I can stay for a show.” I wrapped my arms around her waist, pulled her up to me. “And maybe something else too,” I grinned.

But she turned her face away from me because Mason came out of the bathroom.

“Comedy or drama?” she called down to him, pushing me off her.

“We’re all staying?” I said.

She shot me a look over her shoulder as she meandered into the living room and looked for her remote. “What did you think I meant?” she asked innocently.

“Buddy,” Mason said, throwing his arm around my shoulders. “Truly, that was a fuck of a dish. So this is what Ashes has to come to every night?”

I chuckled. “Hardly every night.”

“She is a hard to please woman, am I right?” he said, and he untied my apron I had been wearing all meal, tossed it on the counter. He steered me with his arm around me into the living room. “Look at her,” he said closely to me.

Ashley was deeply focused on the screen as she scrolled around trying to find the right thing to watch.

“She loves to dress up like that, did you know that about her?”

We stood there together watching her. She grinned without looking up aware now we were watching.

“Oh yeah, she loves to get down and dirty, all feminine, she calls it.” He laughed. “You ever pull her hair? I mean really pull it?”

“I can hear you you know,” she called over through her grin on the couch.

“Girl gets downright squirmy you do that to her.”

He left me there between the kitchen and living room and sat down in the couch and tucked her hair behind her ear. She didn’t react.

“What we got on, Ashes,” he said, and he pulled her hair aside and kissed her neck.

“Down boy,” she murmured, still focusing on typing out the name of the show she wanted. “You coming?” she said suddenly looking up at me and

dropping the remote. The show flashed up on the big screen. “Get the lights, babe,” she said.

I turned the lights down.

“All the way off,” she said.

So I did. I came into the room and sat in the chair opposite the couch.

“You know this one?” she said privately to Mason.

He had thrown his arm around her and pulled her close. She allowed him to, pulling up her legs under her, still in that sparkling tight red dress. She looked up at him closely. “Off or on?” she said privately.

He kissed her and whispered in her ear. She eased her pumps off her feet and leaned back against his shoulder.

“Doesn’t matter, it’s still super funny,” he said. “You know this one?” he called over to me. “Super fucking hilarious.”

“I do not,” I said and I folded my arms over my chest.

We watched the show and though I felt tense about Ashley sitting on the couch with Mason instead of with me, I also couldn’t keep my resentment up and at the same time, keep laughing with them at the show.

But aside from Ashley slapping his leg every time it got to a part she knew, or him playfully tugging her hair but not too hard, what earlier upset me passed. I began to see what she always told me, that he was just a big physical guy who related to people through touch. I could see it now.

In the show, something happened to the lead character causing her dress to fall off. It was in a night club scene and it was pretty funny. She ran screaming covering herself.

“You should take this off,” Mason said.

“You wish.”

“Come on.”

“I think not.”

“It’s just Colin and me.”

“Smarten up Mason,” she said with semi-serious tone.

“Nothing he hasn’t seen, right? Colin,” he called over at me, even as he pulled the tiny shoulder strap off her shoulder so it hung limp over her bicep. “You’ve seen her, right?”

I rolled my eyes at him. “What do you think?” I said and I sneered and grinned at the question.

“See?” he said closely to Ashley’s ear.

“You’re asking for it,” she murmured low under her breath, but she was grinning, still pretending to watch the show with exaggerated focus.

He pushed the other thin strap off her opposite shoulder and now both hung loose down her arms.

“I am warning you,” she said.

“You wear that underwear?”

She glanced at me but I quickly made myself look at the screen. I didn’t want to be caught staring.

“No of course not.”

“But I asked you to.”

The conversation was hushed and private but I could hear everything.

“Too bad. I put on my grandma white cotton undies instead, too bad for you.” She smirked and chuckled.

“I don’t believe you,” he said, and he made to touch her leg at the hem of her dress.

“Touch and you die,” she murmured.

He snickered and pulled them hem up an inch.

“Colin, please inform Mason that I am your girlfriend and that he is not allowed to touch me like this.”

“Mason, seriously,” I said, “maybe knock it off.”

We all went back to watching the show. But her shoulders straps remained loosely dangling over her arms and Mason’s hand remained between her bare thighs below on the hem of her dress.

It was a hot style of dress with a big zipper that ran down the middle of the entire front. The big black metal tag hung like a distraction off the bottom hem.

Mason toyed with it in his fingers, flicking it and tugging it. It was just dark enough when the screen was at a darker scene that I wouldn’t be able to see it at all, but Ashley shifted on her cushion and now leaned squarely back against the side of Mason with her bare feet up on the couch cushions in front of her, her legs straight out.

Mason leaned against the arm of the couch behind him, his knees half pulled up so that Ashley was sitting between them, her elbows hooked around his knees as she leaned back into his chest. He continued playing with the zipper tag down between her legs, all of us watching the comedy show like we were watching some serious drama, everybody focused on the screen.

“Hey Colin?” Mason quietly called over to me.

I slowly turned my face toward them on the couch.

“You know we’re just messin’ right?”

He used a hushed tone as if Ashley wasn’t right there, as if she couldn’t hear him. But she pretended to be solely focused on the show and not able to hear him anyway.

“We’re just friends like she’s been tellin’ you, you know that right?” He pulled on the zipper tag and the big black teeth separated about an inch up.

“I know that, Mason. She told me.”

“She tell you what we used to do?” he said, a grin spreading across his face.

I grinned too. His smile was infectious like that. “No, I don’t think she did.”

“Mason,” Ashley intoned through closed teeth.

He pulled the zipper another couple of inches up. “She tell you we used to...” he started, but he stopped himself. He pulled the zipper a few more inches further up.

I swallowed and glanced down. It was too dark to see anything.

“You know, right?” he said.

I didn’t answer him. Ashley’s eyes closed and her head slowly fell back into his chest. She wasn’t watching the show any more than Mason or I were.

He pulled the zipper up all the way to the top at her chest, slowly and carefully, nearly silently. Ashley curled her lips between her teeth and raised her eyebrows even with her eyes still closed.

“You seeing this?” Mason said in that hushed voice and wide grin.

My breathing came hard and fast. My heart rate began spiking. The show droned on with canned laughter every few seconds.

Ashley’s dress fell open a couple of inches. Mason spread it open more with gentle tugging. Ashley brought her hands around and tried to pull her dress closed over her chest, but Mason gently and carefully gathered up her wrists and took them in one hand down behind her back. He pulled at her dress so she wasn’t sitting on it anymore, slowly peeled it off her shoulders, and then away from her entirely, and he draped it over the back of the couch.

“There we go,” he said in cooing voice. “You seen her in this before?”

He meant her grey and black satin bra and panties, stylish and expensive. I could only shake my head no. My throat was so dry, my voice was stuck.

“She told me you never got to see it,” Mason said. “I told her, show him, let him see it, it’s beautiful on her, but she didn’t think so.”

I shook my head no, transfixed by what he was doing to her, stunned silent by how she was letting him.

She seemed to shiver but it wasn’t cold. “Don’t you think she’s beautiful in these?” he said as he lightly dragged the backs of his knuckles down the side of her breast inside the bra.

Her body straightened and her breath caught. “Mason I don’t... “ she began but he pushed his face into her hair and said, “Sh-sh, he’s loving it.”

Ashley opened her eyes at that point and turned them toward me dark and glassy. We stared at each other as Mason moved his fingertips over the front of her bra cups, touched and then twisted her erect nipple, one and then the other, and she inhaled sharply and dropped her mouth open at me.

“Do you want him to stop, baby?” she said in a nearly inaudible voice.

“Stop what?” I said.

Mason grinned at my answer and leaned down over her shoulder to whisper in her ear but she twisted her head and caught his mouth with hers and her whole body writhed between his knees as they necked long and deep. She seemed to struggle to free her hands from where he held them behind her back but when he did let go she kept them there, pushing them down further, her shoulder and arms working.

His one hand cupped her jaw, his other hand moved from her bra down her ribs, over her stomach, and down further until his fingertips touched and dragged her skin along the top of the waist of her panties.

“She didn’t want to show you her new panties and bra because I bought them for her,” he said to me.

“You bought them,” I repeated.

“When I stayed over.”

While he talked, Ashley reached with her twisting body to find his neck and his chin above and behind her with her mouth.

“Watch, Colin,” he said. “Watch this,” and he wrapped his hand slowly up in rounds of her hair. And then he tugged hard.

Ashley’s body leapt up, her hips shot forward and lifted off the couch, and she whined into the skin under his chin. Her feet kicked out, her knees

pulling up and shooting down over and over, her heels unable to find purchase in the cushions.

He moved his fingertips inside the waist of her panties an inch. Her hips leapt and crunched, they twisted side to side, and she dug her heels in and pressed her shoulders back. Her eyes were closed the whole time.

“You ever seen her like this before?” Mason said quietly to me, always with that grin.

How would I say no? Of course not. I’d never seen a woman in that state anytime anywhere in reality or on film. Her whole body was undulating with waves that rippled across her, everything in her in slow motion movement, her breath hard and shallow and fast, her mouth gaping for lack of something, anything to kiss or suck, until he put two fingers in her mouth, down which she sucked hard and she moaned fiercely.

“You ready to see her really get off, Col?” He said.

I was frankly afraid of what he was doing to her. I didn’t know how to answer, but I wouldn’t have even if I did. I had no voice, I barely had breath.

Ashley wasn’t hearing him or me anymore. She was completely somewhere else by then. Her hands were rising and plunging down behind her lower back. She was fully lifting herself on her heels and shoulders pressed down and back. Her hips circled wherever he touched the front of her panties. A large wet spot appeared in the middle of the shiny gray fabric.

Mason kissed her and she twisted and gasped. He lifted the waist of her panties and her hips shot up and down rapidly. He moved his hand flat against her stomach down under her panties and she cried up into the skin of his neck nearly twisted all the way around backward.

I could tell he was touching her now in her folds, though all I could see were the lumps of his knuckles pressing on the underside of the fabric of her panties. Ashley was panting now, hyperventilating almost, her hips pushing up and down rhythmically, her eyes clenched shut and her mouth pulled back in a grimace.

He must have entered her. She stretched back and let her knees fall wide open. Her body seemed to lose all its bones. She sighed out loud and nearly fell out of the embrace of his legs sideways, she was so loose. “Baby,” she breathed, and a smile opened up across her face.

But then she quickly said, “Shit,” and pulled her dress up from the back of the couch and covered herself with it like a towel, and she rolled out of

his knees and hurried bent over away and down the hallway and into the bedroom.

“Maybe she’s embarrassed,” Mason explained. “Give her a few minutes, she’ll be fine.”

I looked from him to our closed bedroom door, the light on under the crack, unsure if I should follow her or stay. I started to get up but Mason shook his head no at me, and calmed with me with his hand. “She’ll be fine. She didn’t want to watch, that’s all. She didn’t think you were ready. I told her you were, but... “

I turned my face back to the show and it was as though someone turned the volume back on. My reeling mind got lost in the new line of jokes and at some point, Mason gestured at me with his chin, pushed up from the couch, found his stuff, and slipped on his shoes. “Dinner was primo,” he said in a hush from near the door, and he gave me a thumbs up and big wink, and then he was out and gone.

I remained in the chair glued in place. Sometime later, Ashley came out in her house robe. She dashed to the bathroom and I heard water run and the toilet flush. She came out cleaned of all her make up and with her head down, she dashed to me and curled up in my lap hanging her arms around my neck.

“Do you want to talk?” I said.

She said nothing but she shook her head no.

I kissed the top of her ducked head. “Do you want me to stay tonight?”

She said nothing but she quickly nodded her head yes and hugged my arm tightly to her body. We went to bed eventually still saying nothing, and she faced away from me but pulled me, reaching behind herself, up against her and made me spoon her deeply until she was asleep.

I woke up the next morning alone in her bed. I pulled on clothes and peered out the door. Was she even at home? I crept out to the kitchen to find her bent over the counter with a bagel in her mouth and a coffee in her hands scrolling through her phone.

“Babe!” she announced full of surprising cheer, and she flipped her phone over and tore off a chunk of bagel in her teeth and threw herself at me, arms around my neck, and she laughed as she nearly choked on bagel even while she was kissing me with her lips pressed to mine.

She erupted in laughter and sprayed crumbs and covered her mouth with her hand. “Sorry!” she cried out and she laughed harder at herself. “Coffee

for you!” she shouted and she poured a mug out.

I half grinned but half turned away, one eye squinting.

“What?!” she said, seemingly on the verge of bursting out laughing again.

“Just...” I started.

She nodded and calmed me with her hand patting the air between us. “I know, I know,” she rolled her eyes. “Got a little carried away last night.” She shrugged at me and sipped her coffee. “It happens, right?”

“Does it?” I said, grinning back at her by recoiling with her head.

“I told you, Mason makes a living out of pushing boundaries, the things I’ve seen him do!” She laughed a forced laugh and shot her head back. “It’s embarrassing, honestly.”

“What was that, last night?”

“Oh that?” she blew a raspberry and turned her face sideways. “You mean when I ran away?”

“Well yeah that too, but sort of what happened just before that too.”

“Colin,” she said, and she put her coffee down and took both my hands in hers and turned them palm up as though to read them. “I’ve told you, haven’t I? That nobody has ever made me feel as safe as you do, as cared for, as looked after.”

“Okay.”

“Just okay?” she laughed. “I’m baring my soul to you and all you have is okay?”

“I’m still a little stunned about last night.”

“Last night, I’m trying to tell you about last night, last night was, how do I say this? It was magical, it was like nothing else, last night was special, and do you want to know why?” She brought my hand up to her face, rubbed her cheek through my palm.

“Okay, why?”

“Because with you I felt completely safe, I was able to open myself up to you, I was able to be me, like really me!” she said, pressing her hand into her chest.

She pulled my hand and pressed it to her chest between her breasts.

“Feel that? Sh! Feel that?”

I felt her heart beat. I also realized she had nothing on under her top, and I realized it was one of Mason’s old band t-shirts, torn and stretched.

“Your heart?”

“My heart,” she said nodding yes. “It’s not beating hard, is it,” she said. “It’s not racing at all.”

“No.”

“No, and that’s all because of you. That’s what you do for me, you are like my emotional centre. You are like the middle C guitar string, solid, centering, always there.”

“And what’s Mason?”

She turned away from me and dropped my hand and dumped the remainder of her coffee down the sink. “Mason is always just going to be Mason,” she said. She looked over her shoulder at me as she drifted to the other end of the kitchen. “He means nothing to me.”

“Are you sure about that?”

She stretched her arm out behind her, clutched at the air with her fingers grasping at me. “I’m going back to bed,” she said. “You can join me there if you want.”

She pulled the torn and stretched t-shirt up over her head, made sure I saw her drop it in the hallway, and she pranced in different panties through her bedroom door. “Waiting!” she called from her bed.

We met at her neighborhood cafe, Ashley and me, a week or so later. When I sat down with our cups, she clasped her hands around hers, drank from it, and went “mmm!” almost too loud.

“Sooo,” she started. She looked up from her ducked-down face and through fallen strands of hair. She was grinning crookedly. “I know how you’re going to react, but hear me out, first?” She clasped my hand in hers.

We had actually been doing really well since the whole night on the couch thing. We never talked about it again, but Mason had made himself scarce after that and Ashley was a whole lot more amorous with me in ways she had never been before. I wasn’t about to upset the winning streak.

“What is it?” I said.

“It’s just a little thing.”

“Just tell me what it is”

“It’s a music festival.”

“Okay.”

“Three days, sort of, Friday and Saturday night, but I come home Sunday.”

“Right. What’s the catch?” I didn’t see it coming at all.

“Mason has to go to it. You know how he is. I have to help him out, he’s so useless. I didn’t want to go, I told him no, but he insisted.”

“He’s making you go?”

“He’s making me, but he wants to pay my whole way.”

“Mason? I didn’t know you were talking to him.”

“Oh, babe,” she said, and she shrugged at me. “We thought it best to keep it on the down low, you know, not put things out in front of you like that.”

“You’ve been seeing him?”

She laughed with her head thrown back. “Not seeing him seeing him, you make it sound like I’m dating him!”

“No I mean seeing him.”

“Well Col, yeah, he’s my friend...”

“I just, I didn’t know.”

She wrapped her hand around my forearm, rubbed my wrist with her thumb. “You knew, sure you knew.”

“No, I didn’t.”

She chuckled and tilted her head sideways. “I told you I was ‘going to bed early?’” she said, using air quotes and she scrunched her shoulders up and grimaced at me.

“I thought...” I started but I didn’t finish. She’d told me that several times in the past couple of weeks.

“I honestly thought...”

“Nevermind, yeah, I knew, you were using a code, I totally know that, of course,” I said and I laughed out loud. “I mean come on.”

“Right?” she said, laughing too.

“So anyway, he wants to bring me.”

“Well then go.”

“Not like this,” she said. She smiled at me with sympathy on her face. “I want you to be comfortable with it too.”

“You want me to be okay with your going off for a weekend with this guy, what in tents?”

“Well one tent,” she said, “but yeah.”

“In one tent. Just you and him.”

“You make it sound so bad,” she said, falling back in her chair and she crossed her arms over her chest and shook her head at me.

I leaned over the table closer to her, and in a hushed but harsh voice, I said, "I know what you're going to be doing there!"

She leaned over the table too and brought her face up close to mine. "We're going to use protection of course!"

I flung myself back in my chair and looked side to side, even behind me, anywhere but at her.

"Just think about it," she said. "Of course I'll tell him no if you say you can't handle it."

"If I can't 'handle it'?" I said with air quotes of my own and I rolled my eyes at her.

"We should get out of here and walk and talk," she said.

I stormed out of my chair and went outside and started walking. She had to jog to catch up. She pushed her arm through my elbow and we walked at least a block in silence.

"If that's who you want to be with," I said, "then go be with him."

She snorted and shook her head and grinned at the sidewalk. "You don't understand. I keep telling you I want to be with you."

I stopped and faced her but she drove me on, kept us walking. "I was actually thinking about asking you if you thought we should move you in to my place. I mean, we've been getting along really well lately, wouldn't you say?"

"Move in?"

"I feel like it's time."

"Into your place?"

She stopped me now, made me turn to her. "Wouldn't that be nice? Waking up together every morning? We could make each other coffee," she pushed herself up on her toes. "I could make you your lunch!" She rubbed her nose against mine.

"Save on rent, that's for sure," I said.

"See? So many reasons, right?"

We walked along further now hand in hand. "In fact," she said, "you could even move your stuff this weekend, while I'm out, I won't be in your way, I won't be trying to take over, I won't be micromanaging you!"

"Cause you'll be at the music festival."

"I'll be at the music festival, and imagine the nice surprise for me when I come back and find you living there! You could even make a dinner for me! In my kitchen for me when I get back! I'll be hungry."

“In our kitchen,” I said, and she laughed and kissed me on the mouth. “In our kitchen, right!” she said and she laughed.

Friday she got ready. “Mason is picking us up at 4,” she shouted from the bathroom.

“Us?” I said coming into the bathroom doorway.

“Me I mean!” she laughed.

“Nice underwear,” I said.

She turned to me and drew her hand down her body like she was displaying herself. “Mason’s of course,” she said.

“I remember.”

She leaned her hips into the edge of the counter and pressed herself close to the mirror. “Don’t make me laugh this is careful work.” She was doing her eye liner.

“Kind of heavy make-up for a music festival, isn’t it?”

“You have no idea of the pressure us girls are under to look cute.” She turned to me. “Can’t have your man looking around at somebody else!” she laughed and poked me in the stomach. “Have you thought about what you’re making me for dinner on Sunday?”

“Haven’t thought about it yet.”

“Oooh! A surprise!” She pulled on a tight sleeveless t-shirt and stepped into her short denim shorts. “Ugh! The button on these is so hard!”

I helped button them up for her, and drew up the tiny fly.

She went into the bedroom and came out with platform sandals and flat sandals. “Which which?”

“Is there a lot of walking?”

She thought a minute. “Yes!” and she put the platforms back. “See, I need you! You’re so smart!”

Her phone buzzed and she dove at it. She laughed reading the text then held up the camera and made a face and a peace sign at the camera. Then she gave it to me. “Hold it for me! He’s Facetiming me.”

It buzzed before I had time to do anything. She went to the edge of her bed and finished stuffing her duffle bag as she looked up and talked and laughed with Mason on her phone that I held for her. I made to say something but she waved me off with her hand unseen.

“Looking forward to it, Babe!”

“You almost ready? I’ve like five minutes out. We’re short on time already.”

“Well whose fault is that?”

“Just be down there when I pull in.”

“So demandful! I swear.” She rolled her eyes at me in private.

“You wearing what I want you to wear?”

She leaned in close to the phone and pushed her lips to the camera.

“What do you think, baby?” she said and she laughed.

“Colin there with you holding your phone?”

“No!” she said but she laughed with nervous release.

“How you doin, Col?” he shouted.

I turned the phone around to wave at him.

“Something I was meaning to ask you, Col.”

“What’s that?”

“Why didn’t you offer to take her, she wanted to go so bad?”

I looked at Ashley, but she turned her face away as though she needed to closely study the contents of her bag.

“I thought she said you needed to go, she was helping you out.”

Ashley abruptly came up from her bag and snatched her phone out of my hand and turned it toward herself. “You remember what you said?”

He paused a moment, then went, “Ohhh yeah! That... What I said.”

“The industry thing?”

“Right right.”

“Anyway,” she said, and she held the phone up high overhead and made her peace sign and funny face. “You like?”

“Tilt down, down, down, further down.” There was a pause. “Okay, up, up.” There was another pause. “Nearly perfect, but I love the platform sandals.”

“Not so good for walking,” she said, nodding at me as a gesture of recognition for my point.

He laughed. “You’re not going with me for a walk,” he said.

She shrugged at me and kicked off the flat sandals and sat on the edge of the bed and wiggled her feet at me and nodded.

I got down on a knee and fitted her platform sandals to her feet, did up the straps.

“Oh, and this,” she said privately to me.

She handed me a sparkling bracelet. I reached for her wrist but she held up her ankle at me. “Here, here,” she said, and I closed it around her left ankle.

She took the phone from me and aimed the camera down at her ankle.
“You approve?”

“I thought you said you were only going to put that on later,” he said.

She didn’t reply. She kissed the camera again and said, “See you down below,” and ended the call.

“So you can move my stuff around the kitchen anywhere you want, I hardly cook at all, it’s all yours, and I already cleaned out two drawers in the bathroom, right side.” She shrugged and looked around. “Do what you want, I totally trust you, there’s already empty drawers in the dresser, there’s a total empty closet.”

“I don’t know, maybe we’re rushing things.”

She threw her arms around my neck. “Aw, is baby getting cold feet?” She pushed her hand down the front of my pants, inside my shorts even, and she lightly stroked me, squeezed me. “Just imagine, this could be yours every night...” she said, and she chuckled and turned for the door. As she passed the bathroom, she stopped, said, “Oh! Whoops!” and ducked inside.

I saw her whip open a drawer and pull up a fresh box of condoms that she dropped into her duffle bag. “Almost forgot!” she said, and she scrunched her shoulders up and waved at me with fluttering fingers as she went out the front door.

I looked around the place with my hands on my hips. It was bigger than mine, nicer air, nicer light, too. Once I got done with rearranging a few things, hanging a few things on the wall, maybe ordered up some new furniture, I knew I could make it actually pretty nice.

I went home to pack up my stuff. I mean, what else was I supposed to do?